

MUSKETS AND RIFLES (1853–70)

Percussion ignition, whether using caps (see pp.80–81) or other devices, was a major improvement over the cumbersome flintlock. Not only was the percussion mechanism easier to use and maintain, it was also more weatherproof. In another key development, most European and American infantry had their smoothbore muskets replaced with muzzle-loading rifles, which had an accurate range several times greater than that of the musket.

▼ FUSIL REGLEMENTAIRE

MLE 1853

Date 1853

Origin France

Barrel 40½in (103cm)

Caliber .71in (18mm)

For its final smoothbore musket, France maintained its established form of percussion firearms. This musket had a small spherical nipple seat on top of the breech of the steel barrel. It was fired by a strong and simple back-action lock—a percussion-cap variant in which the mainspring inside the lock plate lay behind the hammer, not in front of it, giving the lock a more slender appearance. This would be one of the last new patterns of smoothbore musket issued to European troops.



▲ WHITWORTH RIFLE

Date 1856

Origin UK

Barrel 36in (91.45cm)

Caliber .45in (14.3mm)

Sir Joseph Whitworth (see p.98) produced a rifle for a British Army trial with a hexagonal bore that fired a hexagonal bullet. It proved to be accurate over 1,500 yards (1.4km), but it was four times the price of an Enfield Model 1853 (see pp.100–01), and never adopted by the army.